IMO session brief notes

107th session of the Maritime Safety Committee (MSC 107) 31 May – 09 June 2023

The 107th session of the IMO Maritime Safety Committee (MSC 107) was held 31 May – 9 June, 2023 in person supplemented by online participation. Main outcomes of the meeting are given below.

Revised Road Map for Marine Autonomous Surface Ships

The Committee noted the outcome of MASS-JWG 2 and the progress made in developing a draft goal-based non-mandatory MASS Code for cargo ships to which the SOLAS Convention applies, as well as confirmed the application of the MASS Code would include high-speed craft.

The MASS Code should not repeat provisions or regulations of existing IMO instruments and the definition of "modes of operation" was agreed in principle.

The IMO has finished the Regulatory Scoping Exercise (RSE) for the use of Maritime Autonomous Surface Ships (MASS). This review of all MSC instruments has been completed and can be found in MSC.1/Circ.1638 Outcome of the Regulatory Scoping Exercise for the use of Maritime Autonomous Surface Ships (MASS).

The Committee approved a revised Road Map for the development of a goal-based MASS Code. Work will progress over the next sessions of the Committee, to adopt a non-mandatory goal-based MASS Code in 2024, and later adopt a mandatory MASS Code for entry into force by 1 January 2028.

This code would initially be applicable to cargo ships only while in development and eventually be applicable to passenger vessels once finalized and made mandatory.

The Road Map for a goal-based MASS Code has been updated to be further implemented through the work plan in the following MSC sessions:

- MSC108:

- Consideration of the outcome of the ISCG and MASS-ISWG 2;

- Consideration of the outcome of LEG 111;

- Continue the development of the non-mandatory MASS Code with a view for potential finalization;

- Consideration of input for the JWG;

- Identify changes to existing IMO instruments, make recommendations on addressing the changes, and consider recommendations from the Joint MSC/LEG/FAL Working Group;

- Identify matters for Sub-committees' consideration and liaise with international organizations ILO, ISO, IHO, IALA, and IMSO;

- Consider amending non-mandatory MASS Code, including Interim Guidelines on MASS Trials (MSC.1/Circ.1604);

- Consideration of the scope and framework of the mandatory MASS Code.

- MSC109:

- Finalization and adoption of the new non-mandatory MASS Code;

- Commence development of the mandatory MASS Code, based on the non-mandatory Code, and consider amendments to SOLAS (new chapter) for the Code's adoption;

- Commence the review of existing IMO instruments, under the purview of MSC, considering the adopted non-mandatory MASS Code and the RSE (MSC.1/Circ.1638).

- MSC110:

- Finalization and approval of the mandatory MASS Code and draft SOLAS chapter;

- Further development of consequential amendments to existing instruments.

- MSC111:

- Adoption of the new mandatory MASS Code;

- Further development of consequential amendments to existing instruments.

Agreed Structure for the Draft MASS Code

Acknowledging that future work may lead to numerous changes, the Committee noted the progress made by correspondence groups and working groups leading to the following agreed structure for the draft MASS Code:

- Part 1 - General

1 Introduction
2 Application
3 Code Structure and Relationship to Other IMO Instruments
4 Terminology and Definitions
5 Certificate and Survey

- Part 2 - Main Principles for MASS and MASS Functions

1 Operational Context
2 Safe States for the Ship
3 Functions Required for MASS
4 Risk Assessment
5 System Design Principles

- Part 3 - Goals, Functional Requirements and Provisions

1 Navigation
2 Remote Operations
3 Communications
4 Subdivision, Stability and Watertight Integrity
5 Fire Protection / Safety
6 Life Saving Appliances and Equipment
7 Management of Safe Operations
8 Controlling the Operation of Ship
9 Security
10 Search and Rescue
11 Cargo Handling
12 Personnel Safety and Comfort
13 Towing and Mooring
14 Marine Engineering / Machinery Installations
15 Electric and Electronic Engineering / Electric Installations
16 Maintenance and Repair
17 Emergency Response
18 Care for Persons Onboard

- Part 4 - Specific Provisions for Remote Control of Ship Functions

- Annex - MASS Trials – MSC.1/Circ.1604 – Interim Guidelines for MASS Trials

To progress the work of developing goals and functional requirements of the above listed sections of the draft Code, volunteering member States have divided up these sections and will develop draft text for review at a future session.

New SOLAS Regulations for Onboard Lifting Appliances and Anchor Handling Winches (OLAW)

The Committee adopted Resolution MSC.530(107) amending the SOLAS Convention to introduce new requirements for onboard lifting appliances and anchor handling winches, including a new SOLAS regulation II-1/3-13, which were approved in principle by MSC 102 and were pending formal adoption.

These regulations apply to both new and existing ships.

The new regulations will enter into force on 1 January 2026 and prescribe requirements for the design, construction and installation of lifting appliances and anchor handling winches.

- Lifting appliances are defined as all load-handling equipment onboard ships which are used to handle cargo, stores, hold hatch covers or moveable bulkheads, engine-room equipment, cargo hoses, tender boats and personnel (via cranes);

- Anchor handling winches are defined as any winch for the purpose of deploying, recovering and repositioning anchors and mooring lines in subsea operations. This is not to be confused with a ship's windlasses.

All lifting appliances and anchor handling winches, regardless of the installation date and all loose gear utilized with any lifting appliances and anchor handling winches, are required to be operationally tested, thoroughly examined, inspected, operated and maintained based on the Guidelines referenced below.

New installations of lifting appliances will be required to meet the requirements of a classification society and new installations of anchor handling winches to be to the satisfaction of the Administration, taking into account guidelines for each which have been developed (detailed below).

New definitions and terminologies have been added to SOLAS regulation II-1/2. The new regulation II-1/3-13 will not apply to lifting appliances used on MODUs and offshore construction ships (i.e. pipe/cable laying, offshore installation vessels) and will not apply to lifesaving launching appliances complying with the LSA Code.

Existing lifting appliances and anchor handling winches must undergo a test and thorough examination based on the below guidelines by the first renewal survey after entry into force of these amendments.

MSC.1/Circ.1663 -Guidelines for Lifting Appliances:

- Recommendations for design and testing;

- Guidance on operations and record-keeping through a register of lifting appliances to be kept onboard;

- Also addresses loose gear utilized with lifting appliances and recommends a proof test and thorough annual examination of this equipment.

MSC.1/Circ.1662 - Guidelines for Anchor Handling Winches:

- provides design, testing and maintenance recommendations;

- addresses both anchor handling winches and associated loose gear.

Amendments to SOLAS and the FSS Code - Fires on Ro-Ro Spaces and Special Category Spaces of New and Existing Ro-Ro Passenger Ships

The Committee approved several amendments to SOLAS Chapter II-2 and associated codes to improve fire safety requirements on new and existing Ro-Ro passenger ships. The amendments apply to enclosed ro-ro spaces and weather decks intended for the carriage of vehicles on Ro-Ro passenger ships and will introduce several key features intended to improve fire safety.

These amendments address principal fire protection measures, such as fixed water-based fire-extinguishing systems protecting weather decks, openings in ro-ro spaces provided with closing devices, continuous video monitoring for existing ships and safety distance from accommodation and openings of ro-ro spaces and weather ro-ro deck. The implementation date for these amendments is agreed to be 1 January 2026 for new ships and 1 January 2028 for existing ships, provided that the amendments will be adopted before 1 July 2024.

Regarding arrangements for openings in ro-ro spaces and special category spaces on new ro-ro passenger ships, the term "normally occupied service spaces" was approved for service spaces that do not need extra protection beyond the existing requirements in SOLAS regulation II-2/9.2. In addition, it was agreed to delete the option to reduce the safety distance from 6.0 m to 3.0 m when deluge nozzles were provided and decided that windows should be protected by "A-60" class or "A-0" class with a water-based system with an application rate of at least 5.0 L/min per square meter to define in detail the extent of the entire area that needs protection.

Regarding the arrangement of weather decks and special category spaces on new ro-ro passenger ships, it was agreed to use the term "normally occupied service spaces." Considering the safety distance from designated vehicle lanes to accommodation spaces, control stations and normally occupied service spaces in superstructures and deckhouses adjacent to the weather deck, the amended regulations include provisions to reduce the safety distance from 6.0 m to 3.0 m when the boundary within 6.0 m was protected by "A-60" boundary integrity or alternatively, "A-0" boundary integrity with a water-based system with an application rate of at least 5.0 L/min per square meter.

The amended regulations introduce a retroactive requirement for water monitors to protect the weather deck on existing Ro-Ro passenger ships. For existing ships, a fixed water-based fire extinguishing system based on the monitor(s) shall be installed to protect areas on weather decks intended for the carriage of vehicles. In passenger, vehicle, special category and ro-ro spaces where fixed pressure water-spraying systems are fitted shall be provided with suitable signage and marking on the deckhead and bulkhead and on the vertical boundaries allowing easy identification of the sections of the fixed fire extinguishing system. Suitable signage and markings shall be adapted to typical crew movement patterns, considering obstruction by cargo or fixed installations. The section numbering indicated inside the space shall be the same as the section valve identification and the section identification at the safety center or continuously manned control station.

The amended regulations include changes to SOLAS regulation II-2/20.4.1, which involves using heat detectors on ro-ro passenger ships. The substitution of point heat detectors with linear heat detectors was agreed to as an amendment to the regulation. Linear heat detectors shall be tested according to standards EN 54-22:2015 and IEC 60092-504. Alternative testing standards may be used as determined by the Administration. The amendments do not include a substitution of smoke detectors and existing ships shall also comply upon adoption of the resolution by the Committee.

The Committee also approved amendments to the Revised Guidelines for the Design and Approval of Fixed Water-Based Fire-Fighting Systems for Ro-Ro Spaces and Special Category Spaces (MSC.1/Circ.1430/Rev.2) on the definition of the term "free height". A new definition of "height of the protected space" is added and the term "free height" is replaced by "height" throughout the circular.

These approved amendments will be presented to MSC 108 (May 2024) for adoption. The amended revised guidelines MSC.1/Circ.1430 are approved and will be circulated as MSC.1/Circ.1430/Rev.3.

Safety Measures for Non-SOLAS Ships Operating in Polar Waters

The Committee adopted Resolution MSC.530(107) amending SOLAS Chapter XIV for the implementation of safety measures under the Polar Code, for non-SOLAS ships operating in polar waters. These amendments will add a new Regulation 3-1 within SOLAS Chapter XIV, to identify new requirements in the Polar Code which will be applicable to the non-SOLAS ships under consideration. Three specific ship profiles were targeted for application of these additional safety measures:

- Fishing vessels of 24 meters in overall length and above;
- Pleasure yachts of 300 gross tonnage and above not engaged in trade; and
- Cargo ships of 300 gross tonnage and above but below 500 gross tonnage.

The Committee also adopted Resolution MSC.536(107) corresponding amendments to the Polar Code Part I-A to specify additional safety measures for non-SOLAS ships operating in polar waters.

Amendments were made to Chapter 9 (Safety of Navigation) and Chapter 11 (Voyage Planning) to insert new Chapters 9-1 and 11-1 that specially address the above listed ship profiles.

The new Chapter 9-1 addresses the functionality of navigational equipment in low temperatures and latitudes over 80 degrees and the new Chapter 11-1 addresses the considerations that the master shall make when planning a route through polar waters.

For ships flying the flag of an Arctic state, these regulations will apply when the voyage is beyond the outer limit of the territorial sea of that Arctic state. Additionally, because of the lack of SOLAS certification framework applicable to these types of ships, the Committee agreed that the certificate showing compliance with the newly introduced requirements of the Polar Code part I-A, chapters 9-1 and 11-1 should be left to discretion of the Flag Administration.

The entry into force date for these amendments is January 1, 2026, for new vessels and will also apply to existing vessels one year after entry into force.

Mandatory Carriage of Electronic Inclinometers on Container Ships and Bulk Carriers

The Committee adopted Resolution MSC.530(107) that provides amendments to SOLAS Chapter V requiring the carriage of an electronic inclinometer onboard newly constructed containerships and bulk carriers of 3,000 gross tonnage and upwards. The provision of this device will allow the Voyage Data Recorder (VDR) to record roll motion information for the purpose of incident investigation. It will additionally provide critical stability information to the navigational officer onboard each ship, which may help to prevent shifting or loss of cargo in heavy weather.

This new regulation will not apply to cargo ships occasionally carrying cargoes in bulk and general cargo ships carrying containers on deck. It was also determined that electronic or mechanical back-up systems for inclinometers would not be needed, as they were not considered as critical equipment for the safety of navigation, but rather as operational equipment.

Following the above amendments, the Committee adopted Resolutions MSC.531(107) and MSC.532(107) on amendments to the appendices to the annexes to the 1978 and 1988 SOLAS Protocols, concerning the mandatory carriage requirement for electronic inclinometers. The amendments contained within the appendices relate to the introduction of a definition for "containership" in SOLAS chapter V and will necessitate the modification of the certificate appendices for both SOLAS Protocols. These amendments will also enter into force on January 1, 2026.

Prohibition of Fire-Fighting Foams Containing PFOS Onboard Ships

The Committee adopted Resolutions MSC.530(107) amendments to SOLAS Chapter II-2 and Resolutions MSC.534(107) & MSC.535(107) amending the HSC Codes (1994 and 2000) to introduce the prohibition of use or storage of fire-fighting foams containing PFOS (perfluorooctane sulfonic acid) for firefighting on board ships.

PFOS has been deemed hazardous to the marine environment and human beings, and this prohibition will apply to both fixed and portable systems. This prohibition is being introduced into SOLAS and the HSC Codes by the addition of a new section "Fire Extinguishing Media Restrictions" in each respective text, so that it will be easier to include future prohibitions or limitations of extinguishing media shown to be dangerous to people and the environment.

This prohibition will be applicable to both new and existing ships and include prohibiting the use or storage of extinguishing media containing PFOS no later than the date of the first survey on or after January 1,2026 and delivering the prohibited substances to appropriate shore-based reception facilities when removed from the craft.

Ventilation of Totally Enclosed Lifeboats

The Committee adopted Resolution MSC.533(107) introducing amendments to the LSA Code to provide performance requirements for the ventilation of totally enclosed lifeboats. These amendments will require totally enclosed lifeboats to provide a means of ventilation operable from inside the lifeboat at a rate of not less than 5 m3/hour per person, for the number of persons which the lifeboat is permitted to accommodate and for a period of at least 24 hours. Where the means of ventilation is powered, the source of power shall not be the radio batteries and if dependent upon the lifeboat engine, then sufficient fuel shall be provided.

The openings for the ventilation are to be provided with a means of closing that is operable from inside the lifeboat and positioned so as to minimize the ingress of water.

The amendments will enter into force on January 1,2026 and are to be applied to totally enclosed lifeboats installed on or after January 1,2029, where the expression installed on or after January 1, 2029, means:

- For ships for which the building contract is placed on or after January 1,2029, or in the absence of the contract, constructed on or after January 1, 2029, any installation on the ship; or

- For ships other than those ships prescribed in (a) above, a contractual delivery date for the equipment or, in the absence of a contractual delivery date, the actual delivery of the equipment to the ship on or after January 1, 2029.

Corresponding amendments were approved as Resolution MSC.542(107) for the Revised Recommendations on testing of life-saving appliances (MSC.81(70)) requiring that testing of the capacity of the lifeboat's fuel tank, needed to maneuver the lifeboat at a minimum speed of 6 knots for 4 hours, must also include the fuel consumed by the powered ventilation system.

For totally enclosed lifeboats, a ventilation performance test is required with all entrances and hatches closed to confirm the ventilation rate noted above. Additionally, the lifeboat is to be incrementally rotated to an angle of heel of 180° and upon release, the lifeboat is to return to the upright position without the assistance of its occupants.

Revised Standardized Life-Saving Appliance Evaluation and Test Report Forms (Survival Craft)

In conjunction with the adoptions of amendments to the LSA Code, the Committee approved amendments to the evaluation and test report forms emanating from amendments to the LSA Code and Resolution MSC.81(70) on ventilation requirements for totally enclosed lifeboats, which will be released as MSC.1/Circ.1630/Rev.2.

Amendments to the Prototype Testing of Fast Rescue Boats

The Committee confirmed amendments to the Revised Recommendation on Testing Life-Saving Appliances for the Ventilation of Totally Enclosed Lifeboats (Resolution MSC.81(70)) emanating from the amendments to the LSA Code related to the ventilation performance testing, which would also be applicable to fast rescue boats (FRB). Additional amendments concerning thermal performance of immersion suits and updating of reference to an ISO standard on personal flotation devices were adopted.

Life-saving appliances installed on or after January 1, 2029, should conform to the amended prototype tests of lifeboats, rescue boats and fast rescue boats. The amendments are expected to be adopted at next MSC 108 (Spring 2024).

In-Water Performance of SOLAS Lifejackets

The Committee approved amendments to Chapter II of the LSA Code, as well as consequential amendments to the Revised Recommendation on Testing of Life-Saving Appliances (Resolution MSC.81(70)) regarding the performance of life jackets in the water. These amendments covered the following aspects:

- Amendments to the LSA Code Chapter II on the Personal Life-Saving Appliances;

- Life jackets to maintain a minimum buoyancy of 150 Newtons for the duration of the buoyancy test;

- Life jacket to turn the body of an unconscious person to a face-up position where the nose and mouth are both clear of the water;

- Life jackets shall be provided with a retention device to minimize their displacement from the original fitted position on the wearer when subject to dynamic forces such as waves;

- Amendments to the Revised Recommendation on the testing of life-saving appliances MSC.81(70) which includes changes to the buoyancy test, shoulder lift test and the righting test;

- Consequential amendments to the evaluation and test report forms emanating from amendments to resolution MSC.81(70) on thermal manikin tests, for dissemination as MSC.1/Circ.1628/Rev.1. Regarding the low- temperature tolerance time threshold of immersion suits, it was agreed that the amendments to paragraph 3.2.3 of MSC.81(70) on thermal protective tests to include a 15-minute time frame for the thermal manikin tests. This means that a test would be stopped if the core temperature falls more than 1.5 degrees C per hour after the first half-hour, if the skin temperature of the hand, foot, or lumbar region drops below 10 degrees C for more than 15 minutes.

The amendments are expected to be adopted at next MSC 108 (Spring 2024).

Revision of Lowering Speed of Survival Craft and Rescue Boats

The Committee approved the amendments to paragraphs 6.1.2.8 and 6.1.2.10 of Chapter VI of the LSA Code which address the issue of lowering speed for fully loaded survival craft and rescue boats. The LSA Code states that the minimum lowering speed is calculated using the formula S = 0.4 + 0.02H, where S represents the lowering speed in meters per second and H represents the height in meters from the davit head to the waterline when the ship is at its lightest sea-going condition.

However, due to the construction of larger cargo ships with higher launching heights, it has become challenging to maintain the required minimum lowering speed. To address this, a maximum lowering speed of 1.3 m/s is added and recognized the need to include a minimum lowering speed of 1.0 m/s. The amendments are expected to be adopted at next MSC 108 (Spring 2024) and will apply to both cargo and passenger ships.

Single Fall and Hook Systems with On-Load Release Capability

Lifeboats and rescue boats equipped with a single fall and hook system have a similar risk of accidental release during recovery operations as those with twin fall and hook systems. Therefore, they should have similar safety standards since they are used and tested in the same way. In 2020, paragraph 4.4.7.6.17 of the LSA Code was modified to address this issue.

However, it was discovered that deleting a reference to paragraph 4.4.7.6.8 would result in applying it to off-load hooks, which is inappropriate for some mechanically simple off-load hooks with few moving parts.

To resolve this issue, the Committee approved the amendments to Chapter IV of the LSA Code regarding single fall and hook systems. The revised text would retain the agreed-upon amendments to paragraph 4.4.7.6.17 while amending paragraph 4.4.7.6.8 of the LSA Code for clarity. The amendments will be presented to MSC 108 for adoption and are expected to enter into force 1 January 2026.

Amendments to SOLAS and MARPOL on Mandatory Reporting of Lost or Observed Freight Containers

Due to the repeated occurrence of container losses and the danger they pose to shipping, the Committee approved development of amendments to SOLAS Chapter V which will require reporting of freight containers lost at sea or observed adrift at sea. These amendments have been developed to address the navigation hazard represented by freight containers lost at sea and to enhance the position tracking and recovery of such containers.

Revisions to Regulation 31 of this chapter require the master of every ship involved in the loss of freight containers to communicate details of the incident to other ships in the vicinity, to the nearest coastal State and the flag State. In the event that the ship is abandoned or otherwise unable to complete this reporting, the ISM management company of the vessel must assume responsibility for this reporting to the fullest extent possible.

For vessels not involved in a loss incident but observing a freight container drifting at sea, the master of the ship is obligated to report such observations to other ships in the vicinity and to the nearest coastal State. Associated revisions to Regulation 32 of the same chapter provide a list of information to be collected when reporting the loss of freight containers from a ship or the observation of freight containers drifting at sea.

This amendment inserts a cross-reference to the revised Regulations 31 and 32 of SOLAS Chapter V and establishes the reporting of lost freight containers as an obligation under the MARPOL Convention as well.

Amendments to the IMSBC Code Amendment 07-23 to the IMSBC Code

The IMSBC Code undergoes frequent updates and revisions to incorporate new requirements for existing or new substances. To this scope, having considered the amendments (07-23) to the IMSBC Code, Resolution MSC. 537(107) was adopted with entry into force on 1 January 2025, but it may apply in whole or in part on a voluntary basis from 1 January 2024.

The amendment (07-23) of the IMSBC Code includes new or revised schedules for 11 cargoes, as well as amendments to the Code on subjects such as:

- Inclusion of definitions for "dynamic separation" and "Cargoes which may undergo dynamic separation" (the formation of a liquid slurry (water and fine solids) above the solid material, resulting in a free surface effect which may significantly affect the ship's stability) into the forms specifying the characteristics of the cargo and the required conditions for carriage and handling of that cargo;
- Clarifying in the Code the shippers' obligation to declare technical aspects of cargoes;
- Clarifying carriage requirements of spare charges for SCBAs.

Guidelines for the Submission of Information and Completion of the Format for the Properties of Cargoes Not Listed in the IMSBC Code and their Conditions of Carriage

The Committee approved the MSC.1/Circ.1453/Rev.2. on Guidelines for the submission of information and completion of the format for the properties of cargoes not listed in the International Maritime Solid Bulk Cargoes (IMSBC) Code and their conditions of carriage with mandatory entry-into-force date of 1 December 2023.

Guidelines for Developing and Approving Procedures for Sampling, Testing and Controlling the Moisture Content for Solid Bulk Cargoes Which May Liquefy

The Committee approved MSC.1/Circ.1454/Rev.2. on Guidelines for developing and approving procedures for sampling, testing and controlling the moisture content for solid bulk cargoes which may liquefy with mandatory entry-into-force date of 1 December 2023.

Lists of Solid Bulk Cargoes for which a Fixed Gas Fire-Extinguishing System May Be Exempted or for which a Fixed Gas Fire-Extinguishing System is Ineffective

The Committee approved the MSC.1/Circ.1395/Rev.6 on Lists of solid bulk cargoes for which a fixed gas fire-extinguishing system may be exempted or for which a fixed gas fire-extinguishing system is ineffective aiming to provide guidance to Administrations. This circular supersedes MSC.1/Circ.1395/Rev.5.

Revision of the 1979, 1989 and 2009 MODU Codes to Prohibit Use of Materials Containing Asbestos

The Committee adopted Resolutions MSC.543(107), MSC.544(107) & MSC.545(107) that provide amendments to the 1979, 1989 and 2009 MODU Codes establishing a prohibition on new installation of asbestos-containing materials (ACM) onboard offshore units. The amendments will enter into force on January 1, 2024 and apply to all MODUs, new and existing, from that date.

Any repairs, replacements, maintenance, or additions to working parts of a MODU should be documented with a declaration of asbestos-free materials. Existing materials on board before January 1, 2024, can be retained, but they should not be installed unless they are documented as asbestos-free. Audits of asbestos-free declarations for newly installed materials will be conducted during MODU surveys.

In conjunction with the above, MSC.1/Circ.1671 was agreed on the Unified interpretation on implementation of regulation 2.10.3 of the 2009 MODU Code, regulation 2.8.2 of the 1989 MODU Code and regulation 2.7.2 of the 1979 MODU Code, serving to clarify:

- "New installation" of ACM means any new physical installation onboard (i.e. repaired, replaced, maintained or added);
- Documentation practices associated with confirming the absence of asbestos in newly installed materials are subject to audit as per the Safety Management System of the unit; and
- During surveys required by the MODU Codes, Administrations or recognized organizations acting on their behalf should verify that ACMs are not installed on MODUs by reviewing asbestos- free declarations and supporting documentation for the structure, machinery, electrical installations and equipment covered by the corresponding MODU Codes.

The Committee also approved the Guidelines for Maintenance and Monitoring of Materials Containing Asbestos on Board MODUs (MSC.1 /Circ. 1672), to support implementation of the prohibition on ACM on MODUs. The purpose of these Guidelines is to aid in establishing a maintenance and monitoring program for minimizing exposure of anyone on board to asbestos while the MODU is in service or in a shipyard.

Amendments to the ESP Code Amendments to the 2011 ESP Code

The Committee approved an amendment to the annexes of the 2011 ESP Code (2019 Amendments) clarifying the role of Administrations and their Recognized Organizations with regard to approval and certification of a firm engaged in thickness measurement of hull structures.

Due to inconsistency in the definition of "Administration" in the 2019 amendments to the ESP Code (Administration means either the Administration or an organization recognized by the Administration) which is different from the term as defined in the SOLAS, MARPOL and the Load Line conventions, concern was raised that Administrations could be omitted from being able to participate directly in the document review and certification of firms engaged in thickness measurements of hull structures.

Minor revisions were made to confirm the authority of an Administration to participate in these activities. The amendments to the 2011 ESP Code will be progressed to MSC 108 (Spring 2024) for further consideration and adoption.

Amendments to the International Code of Safety for High-Speed Craft (HSC Code)

The Committee adopted Resolutions MSC.534(107) and Resolutions MSC.535(107) introducing amendments to the 1994 and 2000 HSC Codes and shall enter into force on 1 January 2026, relevant to the Record of Equipment for High-Speed Craft Safety Certificate.

Amendments to the Code of Safety for Special Purpose Ships (SPS Code)

The Committee adopted Resolutions MSC.540(107) and Resolutions MSC.541(107) introducing amendments to the 1983 and 2008 SPS Codes and shall enter into force on 1 January 2026, relevant to the Record of Equipment for the Special Purpose Ship Safety Certificate (Form SPS).

Amendments to the International Grain Code

The Committee approved amendments to the International Code for the Safe Carriage of Grain in Bulk (Grain Code) which introduce a new class of loading conditions for special compartments which are defined as "specially suitable compartment, partly filled in way of the hatch opening, with ends untrimmed".

This definition refers to a compartment which is not filled to the maximum extent possible in way of the hatch opening but is filled to a level equal with or above the bottom edge of the hatch end beams and has not been trimmed outside the periphery of the hatch opening by the provisions of regulation A /10.4 of the Grain Code.

In such compartments, the bulk grain shall be filled to a level equal with or above the bottom edge of the hatch end beams but may be at its natural angle of repose outside the periphery of the hatch opening. After loading, only the free grain surface in way of the hatch opening shall be level.

A compartment may qualify for this classification if it is "specially suitable" as defined in regulation A/2.7 of the Grain Code, in which case dispensation may be granted from trimming the ends of that compartment.

Additional amendments in Part B of the Grain Code addressing calculation assumptions have also been made to provide guidance on the assumed slope of the cargo when partly filled in way of the hatch opening with ends untrimmed, for the purpose of determining the assumed volumetric heeling moment.

The above noted amendments are expected to be adopted at MSC 108 (April 2024). The currently anticipated date of entry into force for these amendments is 1 January 2026. The amendments will be applicable to new and existing ships and the stability booklet should include relevant information before the first time a ship is loaded in accordance with the newly specified loading conditions on or after the date of entry into force.

Amendments to SOLAS Chapter II-2 and Unified Interpretations of SOLAS Chapter II-2 and the FSS and FTP Codes (MSC.1/Circ.1456)

The Committee approved amendments to SOLAS Chapter II-2 / Regulation 7.5.5 addressing fire protection of control stations on cargo ships with an added requirement to provide smoke detection in all control stations and cargo control rooms in addition to accommodation spaces.

Consequential amendments to Unified Interpretations of SOLAS Chapter II-2 and the FSS and FTP Codes (MSC.1/Circ.1456) were approved in principle, addressing fire protection of control stations on cargo ships emanating from the amendments to SOLAS regulation II-2/7.5.5 with respect to the protection of accommodation and service spaces and control stations.

These approved amendments will be presented to MSC 108 (May 2024) for adoption. The amended unified interpretations will be approved at that time and will be circulated as MSC.1/Circ.1456/Rev.1.

2023 Code of Safety for Diving Systems

The Committee adopted Resolution MSC.546(107) creating the International Code of Safety for Diving Operations, 2023 (2023 Diving Code) along with guidance on implementation of the 2023 Diving Code.

This Code has been developed to provide an international standard of safety for diving units, which will result in a level of safety for a diving operation on a diving platform equivalent to that required by SOLAS and its application is voluntary.

Ships of no less than 500 gross tonnage may follow the Code and the Administration may also apply these provisions as far as reasonable and practicable to ships less than 500 gross tonnage, ships of any age and other objects acting as a diving unit but to which SOLAS does not apply.

Using a goal-based standard approach, this new Code will apply to all ships carrying diving systems, regardless of whether they are fixed or temporary, surface orientated or saturation. The main objective of the new Code is to achieve the following:

- Verify the suitability of all types of diving systems;
- Verify the suitability of the ship to function as a diving platform;
- Verify the suitability of arrangements for evacuating divers in saturation from the ship to a safe location;
- Verify that, where applicable, the ship's safety management system for diving operations with the ISM Code aligns with the diving organization's safety management system.

The existing instruments 1995 Code (Resolution A.831(19), as amended) and the Guidelines and Specifications for Hyperbaric Evacuation Systems (Resolution A.692(17)) will co-exist along with the new Code upon its adoption.

Diving systems installed on or after 1 January 2024 should comply with the 2023 Diving Code.

The 2023 Diving Code includes the introduction of a two-part certificate system developed to allow the application of temporary and surface orientated diving systems. Namely, the Diving Unit Safety Certificate (DUSC) part I issued to the diving unit and a DUSC Part II issued to the diving system.

The DUSC Part I intends to confirm the diving unit as a whole (ship and diving system), while the DUSC Part II intends to allow a diving system to be portable and owned/operated and classed by different entities than the ship it is installed upon.

Interim Guidelines on Safe Operation of Onshore Power Supply (OPS)

The Committee approved circular MSC.1/Circ.1675 establishing the Interim Guidelines on The Safe Operation of Onshore Power Supply (OPS) Service in Port for Ships Engaged on International Voyages.

The interim guidelines aim to promote an international standard for safe OPS service on ships during international voyages in port. The technical design, installation and testing requirements for the OPS system recommended to be based on the standard IEC/IEEE 80005-1:2019: Utility connections in port – Part 1: High Voltage Shore Connection (HVSC)

Systems – General requirements and the interim guidelines contain further guidance for testing, operation and safety precautions for onshore power supply connection and disconnection.

Sampling of Oil Fuel for Revised MARPOL Annex VI and SOLAS Chapter II-2

The Maritime Safety Committee approved draft MSC-MEPC guidelines for the sampling of oil fuel to ensure compliance with revised MARPOL Annex VI and SOLAS Chapter II-2.

The joint MSC-MEPC circular aims to create a single sampling process for both conventions to obtain representative fuel samples delivered for use on board ships. These guidelines are based on Annex VI to MARPOL 73/78 and resolution MEPC.176(58).

The vessels subject to regulations 5 and 6 of that Annex must record details of fuel oil delivered and used on board. To ensure compliance, the delivered representative fuel oil sample should be accompanied by a bunker delivery note in accordance with regulations. These guidelines also aim to aid in the implementation of flashpoint-related regulations. Sampling serves the purpose of ensuring compliance with Annex VI of MARPOL 73/78 and SOLAS Chapter II-2.

The personnel taking the primary sample should be familiarized with the guidelines and sampling equipment.

The primary sample should be drawn at the bunker manifold of the receiving ship witnessed by representatives for the receiving ship and supplier or by surveyor mutually agreed acting on their behalf.

The fuel delivered to the ship should be obtained at the receiving ship’s inlet bunker manifold and should be drawn continuously throughout the bunker delivery period. A label containing information about the location where the sample was drawn, the date of the delivery, name and grade of bunker, etc., should be secured to the retained sample container and a 600 ml sample size is agreed as sufficient to undertake tests for both flashpoint and sulfur. The retained sample should be kept in a safe storage location, outside the ship’s accommodation, for a period of not less than 12 months from the time of delivery.

Development of a Safety Regulatory Framework Supporting GHG Reduction from Ships Using New Technologies and Alternative Fuels

While considering steps to decarbonize international shipping, including through the adoption of new technologies and use of alternative low and zero-carbon fuels, there would be a need to ensure that this transition happened in a safe and orderly way.

To this scope, the Maritime Safety Committee noted the work under this new output would be continued for many years in the future and that the outcome would need to be constantly updated and established a correspondence group to begin the work for some feasible fuels and technologies.

A key task for the correspondence group should be the development of a record for safety obstacles and gaps in the current IMO instruments that may impede the use of the alternative fuel or new technology.

The Committee agreed to the work to read as "Development of a safety regulatory framework to support the reduction of GHG emissions from ships using new technologies and alternative fuels", with a target completion year as "continuous". A correspondence group to progress the work by identifying and updating a list of fuels and technologies was established to support the new output on the new alternative fuels and new technologies for the safe reduction of ship's GHG emissions and report to MSC 108.

Mutual Understanding on Flashpoint Documentation

The Committee endorsed the following mutual understanding concerning flashpoint documentation, subject to the entry into force of SOLAS regulation II-2/4.2.1.6:

The test method will provide a specified temperature when an ignition source produces a "flash" in the sample. If this flash occurs when the sample has been heated to a temperature below 70°C, this temperature should be reported on the bunker delivery note. If, however, the sample is heated to 70°C and then tested without producing a flash, there will not be an actual measured flashpoint temperature to report, but this is sufficient to establish that the flashpoint is above the 60°C minimum and thus allow for a statement to be made that the flashpoint has been measured at or above 70°C. If heating and testing of the sample has been carried out beyond 70°C and produced a flash, there will be a specific temperature that can be reported.

Interim Guidelines for Ships Using LPG as Fuel

The Committee approved circular MSC.1/Circ.1666 containing the Interim Guidelines for the Safety of Ships Using LPG Fuels. These Interim Guidelines will provide an international standard similar to the IGF Code, with each section of these guidelines utilizing a similar organization of specifying goals and functional requirements which form the basis for the design, construction and operation of ships using LPG as fuel.

The Interim Guidelines often cross-references the IGF Code, including that the IGF Code parts B-1 (Manufacture, Workmanship and Testing), C-1 (Drills and Emergency Exercises) and D (Training) will apply to ships using LPG as fuel unless expressly stated otherwise.

As with the IGF Code, risk assessments will be the basis for designing ships using LPG as fuel safely. The Interim Guidelines contain requirements for several risk assessments beyond those required by the IGF Code. Ventilation safety requirements unique to LPG fuel were introduced in recognition that LPG gas may accumulate at the bottom of rooms or even open deck due to its density. These Interim Guidelines will apply to ships using LPG as fuel to which Part G (Ships using low-flashpoint fuels) of SOLAS Chapter II-1 is applicable and requires compliance with the IGF Code.

Amendments to the IGF Code

Continuing the work from the 8th session of the Sub-Committee on Carriage of Cargoes and Containers, numerous proposed amendments to the IGF Code were approved:

- Amendments to paragraphs 9.6, 9.6.1, 11.6.2, 9.4.7 and 12.5, 13.3 and 6.7.3.1.1 of the IGF Code address venting, pressure relief and ventilation requirements;

- Amendments to paragraph 9.3.1 of the IGF Code focus on failure of the fuel supply essential auxiliaries and accepting a partial reduction in propulsion capability;

- Amendments to part A-1, paragraphs 5.12.1,6.9.1.1, 9.8.1, 9.8.2, 9.8.4 and to part C-1, paragraph 18.4.1.1.1, of the IGF Code address delivery pressure and a vessel’s bunkering line design pressure.

Moreover, the Committee approved an MSC circular on the early implementation of the amendments to paragraphs 4.2.2 and 8.4.1 to 8.4.3 of the IGF Code with focus on the bunkering manifold and use of a dry- disconnect / connect coupling at the bunkering station as well as an emergency release coupler.

The amendments to the IGF Code are expected to be adopted at next MSC 108 (Spring 2024).

Updated Report on the Status of GBS Verification Audits and the GBS Trust Fund and Final Report on the Third GBS Maintenance Audit

To ensure ship safety and enable proper survey and inspection, mandatory standards for constructing bulk carriers and oil tankers have been established by IMO. These standards are detailed in MSC.287(87) and SOLAS regulation II-1/3-10 and verified audits by recognized organizations are conducted in compliance with MSC.454(100) Revised Guidelines.

In the MSC 107 session, an updated report on the status of GBS verification audits and the GBS Trust Fund was reviewed, along with a final report on the third GBS Maintenance Audit and observations from the GBS Audit Team. Additionally, the Committee acknowledged efforts to address common observations from initial and maintenance verification audits.

Delays Affecting the Availability of New GMDSS Equipment Compliant with the Revised Performance Standards Set Out in Resolutions MSC.511(105), MSC.512(105) and MSC.513(105)

The Committee approved circular MSC.1/Circ.1676 addressing concerns of a reported lack of availability of radio equipment complying with the following revised performance standards which are scheduled to enter into force on 1 January 2024:

- MSC.511(105) - Performance Standards for Shipborne VHF Radio Installations Capable of Voice Communication and Digital Selective Calling (revising resolution A.803(19), as amended);

- MSC.512(105) - Performance Standards for Shipborne MF and MF/HF Radio Installations Capable of Voice Communication, Digital Selective Calling and Reception of Maritime Safety Information and Search and Rescue Related Information (revising and consolidating resolutions A.804(19), as amended, and A.806(19), as amended);

- MSC.513(105) Performance Standards for Inmarsat-C Ship Earth Stations Capable of Transmitting and Receiving Direct-Printing Communications (revising resolution A.807(19), as amended).

Noting also that the IEC was expected to complete development of the relevant testing standards by 1 January 2026 at the earliest, the Committee agreed that it was unrealistic for new shipborne VHF radio installations, shipborne MF and MF/HF radio installations or Inmarsat-C ship earth stations to be available for installation from 1 January 2024.

This will be problematic for both new and existing vessels certificated under the SOLAS Convention, HSC Code and MODU Code, which were recently amended to incorporate these new performance standards.

Therefore, member States may allow continued installation of radio equipment complying with the existing standards (i.e. resolutions A.803(19) as amended, A.804(19) as amended, A.806(19) as amended and A.807 as amended) until 1 January 2028.

Guidance on the Validity of Radiocommunications Equipment Installed and Used on Ships

Related to the above consideration of performance standards for various GMDSS equipment, the Committee also approved revision of MSC.1/Circ.1460/Rev.3 which contained guidance that VHF radiocommunication equipment should be updated so that following the first radio survey after 1 January 2024, at the earliest, it meets the arrangements which will be in force by then.

The Sub-Committee agreed that this circular should be updated to extend the deadline for updating VHF radiocommunication equipment to 1 January 2028. The revised circular will be distributed as MSC.1/Circ.1460/Rev.4.

Modifications to COMSAR/Circ.32/Rev.1 – Harmonization of GMDSS Requirements for Radio Installations on Board SOLAS Ships

In order to align with other standard updates for the Modernization of the GMDSS, the Committee approved revisions to guidance for Harmonization of GMDSS Requirements for Radio Installations On Board SOLAS Ships (COMSAR/Circ.32/Rev.1). Numerous revisions were made to avoid non-uniform implementation of GMDSS requirements on or after 1 January 2024.

The revisions made were primarily focused on clarifying requirements for completing Record of Equipment forms related to GMDSS equipment and clarifying questions on duplicate equipment. The revised COMSAR circular will be distributed as COMSAR/Circ.32/Rev.2.

Amendments to STCW Code – New Provisions on Bullying and Harassment

The Committee approved amendments to the STCW Code (table A-VI/1-4) introducing a new competence on prevention and response to bullying and harassment, including sexual assault and sexual harassment (SASH).

This training will be included as a part of the basic training requirements. The training will require individuals to demonstrate competence in prevention of bullying and harassment, which also aligns with existing provisions on bullying and harassment in the Maritime Labour Convention (MLC), 2006, Guideline B4.3.1.

These amendments to the STCW Code will be presented for subsequent adoption at MSC 108 (May 2024).

Amendments to the STCW Convention and Code – Electronic Certificates of Seafarers

The Committee adopted Resolution MSC.538(107) amending regulations I/1 and I/2 of the STCW Convention to incorporate a new definition for "original form of any certificate required by the Convention" to recognize that seafarers' certificates may be issued in paper or electronic form, and to broadly support the trend of digitalization in marine operations.

In relation to these STCW Convention amendments, the Committee also adopted Resolution MSC.539(107) amending section A-I/2 of the STCW Code, to clarify the application of existing terms and terminologies found within the Code to certificates and endorsements produced in electronic form.

The amendments clarify that terms such as "front, "back" and "overleaf" will not be applicable to electronic certificates. Similarly, an official seal as well as a photograph and signature of the seafarer are not necessary for certificates and endorsements in electronic form.

These amendments to the STCW Convention and Code will enter into force on 1 January 2025.

In support of these amendments, the Committee approved circular MSC.1/Circ.1665 containing the associated Guidelines on the Use of Electronic Certificates of Seafarers to clarify the responsibilities of parties involved in cases of recognition of certificates.

Administrations issuing electronic certificates or endorsements should also provide for the verification of such credentials for all parties involved. It is further specified that verification of the authenticity of an electronic certificate should be undertaken via an Internet connection that should be available on the ship.

The seafarer should hold the minimum required data on board, which should be defined by the Administration and would be necessary to initiate a verification procedure. Verification may be obtained through an application, approved stored data, approved unique tracking number, approved seafarer identification number, Quick Response (QR) code, any combination of the above items, or whatever is deemed suitable for this purpose and approved by the Administration.

New Draft STCW-F Code

Concluding a comprehensive review of the 1995 STCW-F Convention, the Committee approved amendments to the STCW-F Convention as well as a new STCW-F Code to support the implementation of the Convention for seafarers employed on fishing vessels.

Numerous revisions to the STCW-F Convention have been made to parallel the scope of the STCW Convention, and to provide a standard better adapted to technological, regulatory, operational and other related industry developments. Similarly, the new STCW-F Code is structured similarly to the STCW Code and is intended to establish clear standards for training, certification and watchkeeping for fishing vessel personnel.

This work to review and update seafarer training standards for fishing vessels was done in support of recent efforts at the IMO to see the 2012 Cape Town Agreement enter into force and establish international standards for the safe operation of fishing vessels. For entry into force, the agreement needs to be ratified by 22 States with an aggregate number of 3,600 fishing vessels operating on the high seas. The current number of ratifications stands at 21 States, with a total of around 2,603 eligible fishing vessels.

The IMO is currently campaigning for Member States to ratify the agreement and have it enter into force in the near future. The revisions to the 1995 STCW-F Convention and new draft STCW-F Code will be presented for subsequent adoption at MSC 108 (May 2024).

Requirements for Emergency Towing Equipment for Ship Types Other Than Tankers

The Committee approved amendments to SOLAS regulation II-1/3-4 requiring all new ships other than tankers of not less than 20,000 GT to be fitted with emergency towing arrangements. The amendments are expected to be adopted at MSC 108 (May 2024) and are anticipated to apply to ships other than tankers constructed on or after the date of entry into force date.

Guidelines for determining the strength and adequacy of the emergency towing arrangements have yet to be developed but are expected to be available prior to the regulation entering into force.

Revision of Water Level Detectors Performance Standards on Bulk Carriers and Single Hold Cargo Ships Other than Bulk Carriers (Resolution MSC.188(79))

The Committee approved a proposal to amend paragraph 2.2.2 of the Revised Performance Standards for Water Level Detectors on Bulk Carriers and Single Hold Cargo Ships Other than Bulk Carriers (Resolution MSC.188(79)/Rev.1) that was adopted at MSC 105, to clearly distinguish installation heights of detectors between requirements of applicable SOLAS regulations:

- The installation heights of sensors at pre-alarm and main-alarm levels, as required by SOLAS regulations II-1/25.3, II-1/25-1.2 and XII/12.1, should be measured from the upper surface of the inner bottom;

- The installation heights of bilge level sensors (an alternative permitted by SOLAS regulation II-1/25-1.3) should be measured from the bottom of the bilge well if the bottom of the bilge well is below the upper surface of the inner bottom.

Additionally, the Committee approved a revision to the performance standard to clarify that the standard is applicable ships constructed on or after 1 January 2024 and applicable to ships constructed prior to that date if water level detectors are installed on or after 1 January, with the word “installed” meaning the contractual delivery date or actual delivery date of the equipment to the ship.

This revised performance standard will be disseminated as MSC.188(79)/Rev.2.

Unified Interpretations of the IGF Code and IGC Code

The Committee approved four circulars containing new Unified Interpretations (UI) related to the IGF Code and IGC Code:

- IGF Code, Paragraph 9.2.2 – Specific Requirements for Ships Using Natural Gas as Fuel / Fuel Supply to Consumers (MSC.1/Circ.1670). This UI clarifies fuel transfer system piping requirements, specifying that use of flange connections should be kept to a minimum.

- IGF Code, Section 5.8 – Design of Fuel Preparation Rooms Not Located on Open Deck (MSC.1/Circ.1667)

- IGF Code, Paragraph 5.11.3 and 12.5.3.2 – Access Arrangements and Associated Hazardous Area. This UI proposes clarifications to certain tank connection space requirements for the design of fuel preparation rooms not located on the open deck.

- IGF Code, Paragraph 15.3.2 – Bilge Well Requirements. This UI clarifies that the bilge well requirements of this section only apply to a fuel preparation room located below deck if that fuel preparation room handles fuel in its liquid phase.

- IGC Code, Cargo Containment / Verification Process (MSC.1/Circ.1669). This UI addresses the verifications and examinations required by the IGC Code during new building gas trials and first full loading and unloading of the cargo. It proposes which items may be completed during the new building gas trials and which items are only feasible during the first full cargo loading/unloading operations.

- IGC Code, Paragraph 11.3.1, 11.4.1, 11.4.3 and 18.10.3.2 – Bunkering Manifold Arrangements Fitted on LNG Bunkering Ships (MSC.1/Circ.1668). This UI addresses the requirements of the IGC Code that detail the fire safety equipment required for cargo manifolds.

The interpretation proposes that any additional cargo transfer equipment connected to the traditional cargo manifold extensions such as transfer loading arms, bunkering booms, transfer hoses, reducers, spool pieces and transfer hose reels should be considered part of the cargo manifold. As such, they should comply with the requirements of paragraphs 11.3.1.4, 11.3.1.5, 11.4.1, 11.4.3 and 18.10.3.2 of the IGC Code for fire detection and fire protection of the cargo area, including hull protection from low temperatures.

Unified Interpretations of SOLAS Chapter II-1

The Committee approved circular MSC.1/Circ.1362/Rev.2 containing two new Unified Interpretations (UI) related to SOLAS Chapter II-1:

- SOLAS Regulation II-1/3-8 – Mooring Arrangements and Equipment. This UI new interpretations clarify the criteria for the application of:

- Revised Guidance on Shipboard Towing and Mooring Equipment (MSC.1/Circ.1175/Rev.1);

- Guidelines on The Design of Mooring Arrangements and the Selection of Appropriate Mooring Equipment and Fittings for Safe Mooring (MSC.1/Circ.1619), and

- Guidelines for Inspection and Maintenance of Mooring Equipment Including Lines (MSC.1/Circ.1620),

and describes the documentation required for demonstrating compliance with these guidelines on mooring equipment.

These circulars will be effective for ships constructed on or after 1 January 2024, except for MSC.1/Circ.1620, which will be effective for all ships from 1 January 2024.

- SOLAS Regulation II-1/13.2.3 – Clarification on Penetrations in Watertight Divisions – Pressure Testing After a Fire Test. This UI concerning penetrations in watertight divisions on a passenger ship for pressure testing after a fire test.

Any penetration used for the passage of heat sensitive piping systems through a watertight bulkhead on a passenger ship must be tested with the heat sensitive piping and approved for watertight integrity post fire.

Additionally, the Committee adopted two additional circulars containing UIs to SOLAS Chapter II-1:

- MSC.1/Circ.1673 – Application of SOLAS Chapter II-1 Regulation 1.1.3. This UI provides interpretation of amendments to SOLAS Chapter II-1 adopted by resolutions MSC.474(102) and MSC.482(103) to clarify the application of several regulations.

The document proposes a unified interpretation about the expressions "ships constructed before 1 January 2024" and "Multiple hold cargo ships other than bulk carriers and tankers constructed on or after 1 January 2024".

-The interpretation addressing Resolution MSC.474(102) clarifies which set of requirements shall apply to ships with a contract date before 1 January 2024 but with a construction date between 1 January 2024 and 1 July 2024;

- For Resolution MSC.482(103), SOLAS regulation II-1/1 defines the term "ships constructed" as those whose keels have been laid or are at a similar stage of construction. However, it does not provide a definition for the term "Multiple hold cargo ships other than bulk carriers and tankers constructed on or after 1 January 2024", thus, an interpretation was required.

- MSC.1/Circ.1557/Rev.1 – SOLAS Ch.II-1 / Regulation 45.11 – Precaution Against Shock, Fire and Other Hazards of Electrical Origin. This UI amends an MSC circular on the Revised Hazardous Area Classification in respect of the selection of electrical equipment, cables and wiring and positioning of openings and air intakes to address inconsistencies between the standard IEC 60092-502 published by the International Electrotechnical Commission (IEC) and relevant IMO instruments.

Unified Interpretations of SOLAS Chapter II-2 – Separation of Ducts from Spaces

The Committee approved circular MSC.1/Circ.1276/Rev.1 containing amendments to unified interpretations of regulations II-2/9.7.2 and 9.7.5 – Separation of ducts from spaces, in the Unified Interpretations of SOLAS Chapter II-2 (MSC.1/Circ.1276) originally developed to address requirements for separation of galley exhaust ducts from the spaces they pass through, in order to align with the provisions of the SOLAS Convention, as amended by the Amendments to the International Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea, 1974 (Resolution MSC.365(93)).

This UI contains diagrams showing various configurations in which a duct that has contiguous boundaries to an enclosed space should be insulated from that space where fire-rated insulation is required as per regulations II-2/9.7.2 and 9.7.5.

Revision to the Unified Interpretations of the 2008 Intact Stability Code (MSC.1/Circ.1537/Rev.1)

The Committee approved circular MSC.1/Circ.1537/Rev.2 containing an addition to the Unified Interpretations of the 2008 Intact Stability Code (MSC.1/Circ.1537/Rev.1) for the interpretation of down-flooding point to be realigned in its scope of application to all criteria addressed by the 2008 Intact Stability Code. The revision clarifies that that this interpretation may be applied to all down-flooding points and is not specific to severe wind and weather criterion.

Unified Interpretations of the LSA Code, the 1994 and 2000 HSC Codes – Life raft Equipment

The Committee approved circular MSC.1/Circ.1674 containing unified interpretations of the LSA Code and the 1994 and 2000 HSC Codes regarding paragraphs 4.1.5.1.13, 4.4.8.16 and 5.1.2.2.7 of the LSA Code – Equipment of life raft, lifeboat and rescue boat, respectively, paragraph 3.8.10 of annex 10 to the 1994 HSC Code – Equipment of open reversible life raft and paragraph 3.8.10 of annex 11 to the 2000 HSC Code – Equipment of open reversible life raft.

The unified interpretation suggests that if a torch uses a filament bulb or a single LED as its light source for the life raft equipment, then a spare bulb must be provided. However, if the torch has multiple LEDs and the failure of one LED does not affect the functionality of the others, then a spare LED is not required.

The provision of a second ready-for-use waterproof electric torch suitable for Morse signaling can be accepted as an alternative to providing one spare set of batteries and one spare bulb in a waterproof container.

This document has been prepared by the Russian Maritime Register of Shipping for reference purposes and contains a summary of the main results of the meeting of the IMO working body. For reference purposes, the document reflects background information on the outcomes of discussions and decisions taken during IMO meetings. Similar information about other IMO meetings is available on the RS website.

If you have any questions, please contact RS International Affairs Department: https://rs-class.org/ru/register/contacts/